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Experiences and perceptions of sexual violence in a UK university: results from the second iteration of the OUR SPACE survey

Bridget Steele , Victoria Tan , Deanna M. Giraldi, Michelle Degli Esposti  and David K. Humphreys 

Department of Social Policy and Intervention, University of Oxford, Oxford, UK

ABSTRACT

Sexual violence is a critical issue within higher education and governments and regulators globally are increasingly mandating institutions to prevent and respond to the problem. Yet, limited institutional-level evidence in the UK links students' experiences of victimisation with their perceptions of institutional responses to sexual misconduct. Analysing data from an online survey administered to all enrolled students at a UK higher education institution in 2024, this study estimates the prevalence and nature of sexual harassment and sexual assault, respondents' feelings of safety, and their perceptions of institutional handling of sexual misconduct. All administered measures were adapted from the ARC3 campus climate survey and SES-SFV instruments. We found high levels of past-year victimisation, with women experiencing substantially higher rates of sexual assault and sexual harassment than men. Perpetrators were predominantly men and most often fellow students, and reported incidents frequently occurred on university premises. Respondents who had experienced sexual violence expressed more negative perceptions of their institution's response to sexual violence, highlighting a significant relationship between victimisation and perceptions of institutional responses to sexual misconduct. Interpreting these findings through frameworks of institutional betrayal, we argue that universities must move beyond compliance to address the cultural and structural conditions that enable sexual violence.

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Sexual violence; sexual harassment; gender; higher education; institutional responses

Introduction

Sexual violence (SV), including sexual assault and sexual harassment among higher education students is increasingly being recognised as a serious issue that undermines student safety, health and well-being, and educational attainment. Globally, 18% of female students and 8% of male students are estimated to have experienced sexual assault during their studies (Steele, Martin, et al. 2024), and on average 25% of female students are estimated to have experienced sexual harassment (Bondestam and Lundqvist 2020). Internationally and in the UK, women and gender-diverse students also face the high rates of violence (Steele, Degli Esposti, et al. 2024; Steele, Martin, et al. 2024). While prevalence estimates for SV vary substantially across studies due to inconsistent use of measurement

CONTACT Bridget Steele  bridget.steele@spi.ox.ac.uk  Department of Social Policy and Intervention, University of Oxford, Oxford, OX1 2ER, UK

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and varying sample sizes, populations, and sampling strategies the collective evidence leaves little doubt that SV is a commonplace reality for students across higher education institutions.

Existing literature on SV in higher education has narrowly focused on reporting prevalence estimates from singular cross-sectional institutional surveys. This paper builds on this literature by providing a comprehensive and holistic quantitative analysis of the experiences of SV among students at a UK university. Importantly, this is the second iteration of this survey at the same institution (Steele, Degli Esposti, et al. 2024). However, in this paper we capture not only the scope and contextual details of assault and harassment but also students' opinions on whether SV is a problem at their institution, their perceptions of safety in relation to SV, and their perceptions of institutional responses to sexual misconduct (a term universities across the UK higher education sector use to define any unwanted conduct of a sexual nature that violates institutional codes of discipline). We also offer insights into the relationship between students' experiences of SV and their perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct at one of the UK's prestigious universities.

In our analyses, we aim to address the following research question: What is the culture and prevalence of sexual violence at a UK higher education institution? To answer this question, we explore the following subquestions: (1) What is the prevalence and nature (location, perpetrator, and type) of sexual assault and harassment among respondents? (2) Do respondents feel safe from SV and have trust in their institution to adequately respond to reports of sexual misconduct? (3) How does experiencing sexual assault correlate with perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct?

Sexual violence in UK higher education

In the UK, awareness of SV in universities has grown significantly over the past decade (Humphreys and Towl 2022), following the significant work done by activists and researchers, in the US. In the UK, the first national study on SV was the NUS *Hidden Marks* survey in 2010 which found that one in seven women respondents had experienced a serious physical or sexual assault and that over two thirds had faced some form of sexual harassment during their time at university (Smith 2010). Then in 2015, Universities UK convened a national task force on violence against women, which resulted in a report that urged all institutions to improve centralised reporting systems, support services, and prevention training and utilise institutional expertise and resources to collect data (UniversitiesUK 2016). This sector-wide focus, alongside continued student activism, led to further academic research. For example, Roberts, Donovan, and Durey (2022) conducted a study in the North of England and found 15.9% of women respondents and 5.4% of men respondents faced unwanted sexual contact. Further, Anyadike-Danes et al. (2022) conducted a study with Northern Ireland higher education students and found that 67% of women respondents and 44% of men respondents reported experiencing an unwanted sexual experience since attending university.

We conducted a prevalence survey as part of the Oxford Understanding Relationships, Sex, Power, Abuse and Consent Experiences (OUR SPACE) project and found that in the past year 20.5% of student respondents had experienced an attempted or completed sexual assault, while 52.7% had experienced at least one instance of sexual harassment, including stalking (Steele, Degli Esposti, et al. 2024). The OfS subsequently delivered a survey to all final year higher education students in England and found that approximately one in four students experienced sexual harassment, one in seven experienced sexual assault, and that women were three times as likely to experience sexual harassment and twice as likely to experience sexual assault when compared to men (2025).

Prevalence cannot be understood in isolation from the organisational cultures and institutional contexts in which it occurs. A growing body of scholarship has examined how aspects of university environments such as peer norms, power hierarchies, and institutional tolerance for misconduct create an environment that can either prevent or enable SV. For example, in the UK, the concept of 'lad culture' has been used to describe a group dynamic, prevalent in some student social circles (for example, in sports teams or clubs), characterised by misogynistic conversation, rape

jokes, and peer pressure that normalises harassment against women (Phipps 2017; Phipps and Young 2013). Phipps and Young (2013) theorise lad culture to be a 'conductive context' for SV through trivialising aggressive and misogynistic sexual conversation and behaviour, enabling and normalising SV. Lad culture in higher education institutions in the UK coupled with feminist understandings of rape culture more broadly, wherein societal norms and sexist attitudes allow sexual aggression to be excused or even expected (Jozkowski et al. 2021; Jozkowski and Wiersma-Mosley, 2017; Phipps et al. 2018; Steele et al. 2022) can help describe how and why SV persists in these settings. Further, organisational culture theories suggest that when university leadership implicitly or explicitly tolerates these types of attitudes and behaviours (through for example, failing to sanction offenders, not taking reports seriously, or keep employing staff who also perpetuate rape culture), it signals an institutional acceptance that can lead to further incidents (Bondes-tam and Lundqvist 2020; Lamothe et al. 2022). Conversely, it could be hypothesised that universities that promote a culture of respect and gender equality, through clear policies, education, and leadership commitment could reduce the incidence of SV.

Higher education institutions are not just social environments where young people operate, they are also formal institutions with duties of care toward their students are increasing and becoming more formalised through policy. In the United States, Title IX legislation has framed SV in higher education as an issue of federal civil rights compliance, and it holds higher education institutions legally accountable for addressing reports of SV. In England, the recent OfS conditions of registration (E6) have specified that education institutions in England must be compliant across a range of activities to prevent and respond to sexual misconduct among students including implementing and communicating accessible reporting procedures, disciplinary procedures, survivor support services, and preventive education. However, in practice, this is likely to vary significantly across institutions. This regulation is encouraging; effective institutional responses can encourage reporting and mitigate harm. However tokenistic responses that encourage reporting without adequately resourced support staff to respond to disclosures or trauma-informed processes to handle cases can lead to revictimisation, perpetration and environments of fear or apathy (Bonar et al. 2022; Hong 2023; Napolitano 2015). Recent evidence from a national UK survey administered by the OfS suggests most student victims still do not report incidents of sexual harassment or assault to their institution; among those who reported sexual harassment 39.3% indicated that the experience was poor and 32.4% of those who reported sexual assault described their experience as poor, citing issues including lack of support or continued exposure to the perpetrator on campus (OfS 2025). This variance in institutional handling highlights the critical question of how universities might themselves exacerbate the harms of SV.

Understanding the relationship between institutional trust and experiencing and reporting SV is important to further unpack theories of institutional betrayal. This concept refers to institutions' wrongdoings or negligence that violate the trust of those dependent on it (Smith and Freyd 2014). Shannon and Bull (2024) qualitatively explored the relationship between institutional trust and betrayal among UK higher education students and found that many survivors distrusted their universities yet still reported forms of gender-based violence because they depended on those same institutions for any chance of resolution. By introducing the concept of 'unwilling trust', the authors show how institutional betrayal can occur when individuals take actions that appear trusting despite lacking genuine trust, often due to limited agency and structural inequalities (Shannon and Bull 2024). In the context of higher education, institutional betrayal could include the perception that a university is covering up reports to protect its reputation, blaming the victim, or responding to reports of sexual misconduct with indifference, inconsistency, or a lack of transparency. Such institutional behaviours can exacerbate the trauma of SV by adding a sense of betrayal and alienation to an already harmed student (Smith and Freyd 2014). Survivors who feel betrayed by their university report heightened psychological distress, reduced well-being, and decreased trust in authority, in addition to the harm caused by experiencing SV (Adams-Clark, Harsey, and Freyd 2024). Moreover, the fear of institutional betrayal can give perpetrators a sense of impunity and can deter students

from coming forward at all, especially those from marginalised groups who may already lack confidence that the system will treat them fairly (Adams-Clark, Harsey, and Freyd 2024). Theoretical frameworks around institutional trust and betrayal therefore offer an important lens for this study's analysis of the relationship between experiencing SV and having trust in the institution.

Critical feminist theories when combined with institutional frameworks on institutional betrayal provide an overarching framework for understanding why SV persists in universities. They can help to explain how gender, power, and identity shape both the occurrence of violence and institutional responses to it. A crucial insight from feminist scholarship is that SV is rooted in power inequalities and acts as a mechanism for reinforcing those inequalities (Armstrong, Gleckman-Krut, and Johnson 2018). In higher education institutions, as in society at large, SV is predominantly a gendered phenomenon; the vast majority of perpetrators are men, and women (along with non-binary and gender-diverse individuals) are disproportionately targeted (Steele, Martin, et al. 2024). This is not coincidental; it reflects broader patriarchal power structures in which men's aggression against women has been normalised. The 'continuum of SV' coined by Kelly (1987) describes how seemingly minor behaviours like sexist jokes or unwanted touching exist on the same continuum as rape, differing in degree but rooted in the same forms of systemic oppressions. Challenging SV therefore also requires challenging embedded power relations and entitlement within institutions and among students. As institutions reinforce or are perceived to reinforce unequal power relations they create environments in which SV could perhaps be normalised and more readily excused and tolerated (Bhopal and Myers 2023).

This theoretical underpinning means that measuring prevalence in isolation is insufficient. More attention is needed to understand if/whether and how students perceive their institutions as being critical actors in protecting students from and responding to incidents of sexual misconduct. Some scholars have developed the term 'institutional courage' (an antidote to institutional betrayal) to describe institutions that model transparency, accountability, and leadership in preventing and responding to SV (Bull 2024; Dufour 2024). This perspective aligns with calls for regular data collection of the prevalence and incidence of SV and reports of SV to institutions combined with public reporting of data and survivor-centred practices as signs of an institution taking accountability. Our study, informed by these concepts, not only assesses the scope and contextual details of the problem at a UK higher education institution for the second time but also students' perceptions of their institution's role in preventing and responding to SV.

Materials and methods

Study design

This study draws on data from the second iteration of the OUR SPACE survey, a quantitative cross-sectional survey of SV prevalence and campus culture. The survey was co-designed with peer researchers, university sexual violence support staff, and administrators, and was sent to all students at a UK higher education institution in 2024. The OUR SPACE study was developed to generate institution-specific evidence on students' experiences of sexual harassment and sexual assault, and to inform institutional policies and practices for prevention and response. Ethical approval was obtained from the University of Oxford's Social Sciences and Humanities Interdivisional Research Ethics Committee [Ref No: R73805/RE001].

Data collection

The survey was disseminated to all enrolled students at the higher education institution via email (approx. 26,000 students). Data were collected in June 2024 over a three-week period, during which two reminders were issued. A total of 1663 students started the survey, of which 1097 students completed the survey and comprised the analytical sample (4% of the total student population). Participants provided informed consent before beginning and were reminded that

participation was voluntary, responses were confidential, and withdrawal was possible at any point prior to submitting the survey. Information about support resources, both within the university and externally, was provided on every survey page. The survey was administered using Qualtrics and accessed via students' Single Sign-On accounts to ensure one response per student. Students could enter a prize draw for one of ten £100 Amazon gift cards as an incentive to increase participation and the response rate.

Survey instrument and measures

The OUR SPACE 2024 survey was adapted primarily from the ARC3 (Administrator-Researcher Campus Climate Collaborative) instrument, a validated measure of sexual misconduct in higher education (Tilley et al. 2020). The ARC3 has been determined to be a reliable and valid instrument to assess the issue of sexual misconduct. The only module that did not have strong internal consistency was the sexual harassment module, however this scale was still used as the field lacks a validated measure for sexual harassment (Swartout et al. 2019; Tilley et al. 2020). This paper focuses on the following domains:

- *Experiences of sexual harassment in the past-year.* Past-year experiences of sexual harassment were measured with 11 items, nine of which were adapted from the Sexual Experiences Questionnaire (Gutek, Murphy, and Douma 2004) and two virtual harassment items were added. Items were scored on a 0–4 scale (0 =Never, 4 =Many times). Subscales included sexist hostility, unwanted sexual attention, and harassment via electronic communication (Swartout et al. 2019).
- *Experiences of sexual assault in the past year.* Sexual assault in the ARC3 survey was measured using the Sexual Experiences Survey Short Form Victimization (SES-SFV), a widely validated instrument assessing unwanted sexual experiences through behaviourally specific items (Koss et al. 2007). Prevalence estimates were calculated for type of assault (e.g. unwanted sexual contact, attempted rape, rape). This scoring accounted for the fact that respondents could have experienced more than one type of assault in the past year and/or the same type of assault more than once. Additionally, scoring was also completed to capture the prevalence of participants who experienced at least one type of sexual assault. The questions on SV employed behaviourally specific and trauma-informed items (Swartout et al. 2019).
- *Contextual questions about instances of sexual harassment and sexual assault.* If participants reported experiencing at least one instance of sexual harassment, they were asked to reflect on the incident that had the greatest impact on them and answer followup questions about that incident of harassment. Participants were asked to indicate the gender identity of the perpetrator and whether the perpetrator was a member of staff or a student at the university (or neither). Participants who reported experiencing at least one act of sexual assault were also asked to reflect on the incident of assault that had the greatest impact on them and answer followup questions about that incident. Participants were asked the same followup questions as listed above for sexual harassment and were additionally asked about whether or not the perpetrator was using alcohol or drugs at the time of the assault and about their relationship to the perpetrator (e.g. friend, acquaintance, romantic partner, or stranger). These questions were adapted from the ARC3 survey (Swartout et al. 2019).
- *Identification of sexual violence as an institutional problem.* An additional single item from ARC3 assessed whether respondents perceived SV as a problem at their institution. Participants responded using a 5-point scale (0 = Strongly disagree to 4 = Strongly agree).
- *Perceptions of safety related to sexual violence.* Perceptions of safety related to SV was measured using three items adapted from the ARC3 Campus Climate Survey, assessing if respondents felt safe from sexual harassment, sexual assault, and stalking (a specific form of sexual harassment) at their institutions. For example, 'as a student at this institution, do you feel safe from sexual ' Participants responded using a 5-point scale (0 = Strongly disagree to 4 = Strongly agree).

- *Perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct.* To assess how respondents think their institution would respond to a report of sexual misconduct, we used an 11-item measure that uses a 5-point scale (0 = Very unlikely to 4 = Very likely). A definition of sexual misconduct was given to participants. All participants responded to this scale regardless of if they had reported experiencing SV as respondents were asked to reflect on how they think their institution would handle a report of sexual misconduct. Three items in this scale were coded (4 = Very unlikely to 0 = Very likely) as they were worded to be negative institutional responses and the remaining items in the scale were worded to be positive institutional responses. This was a subscale included in the ARC3 Campus Climate Survey in a larger module on perceptions of campus climate regarding sexual misconduct.

Data analysis

Descriptive statistics were used to assess demographic characteristics, responses to questions on the prevalence and nature of sexual assault and sexual harassment (including perpetrator characteristics and location and details of the incidents), perceptions of safety and perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct. All analyses were disaggregated by gender identity. To obtain estimates that were representative of the University's student population, data were survey-weighted using an iterative proportional fitting method and the University's available student statistics for 2024. The variables used in the weighting process included: gender (male, female, other), ethnicity (collapsed into white and non-white to account for low sample sizes in some categories), student status (undergraduate, postgraduate, continuing education student, visiting student), and whether students were domestic, international, or EU students. Due to small sizes of non-binary students reported in official University statistics, the weighted sample size of the group was less than 1 and therefore excluded from weighted analyses. Weighted estimates are presented with a 95% CI. We conducted all analyses across both the unweighted and weighted data. The analyses with unweighted data can be found in the Supplementary Material.

We conducted significance tests to determine whether differences in experiences and perceptions around SV across reported gender identity were statistically significant. To test differences in prevalence estimates across men and women we used a Chi-squared test with Rao & Scott adjustment for the survey-weighted structure of the data and to test gender differences across scores on scales related to perceptions of safety and institutional responses, we used a Kruskal–Wallis test.

In addition, we looked at the relationship between experiencing SV and perceptions of institutional trust. We conducted survey-weighted t-tests to assess whether the difference in mean institutional response scores was statistically significant between those who reported having experienced sexual harassment and those who did not. We repeated the analysis with sexual assault estimates. Both analyses were stratified by gender and presented in violin plots to show the difference in distributions of mean scores as well. All quantitative analyses were conducted in R version 4.4.2 (R Core Team, 2024), and using the *survey* (v4.4.2; Lumley 2024), *svyr* (v1.3.0; Freedman Ellis and Schneider 2024), *margins* (v0.25.0; Arel-Bundock, Greifer & Heiss, 2024), and *qualtrics* (v3.2.1; Ginn & O'Brien, 2024) packages. See full citations for R packages at the end of the reference list.

Results

Sample

A total of 1,097 students completed the OUR SPACE 2024 survey. After applying survey weights to reflect the wider student population, the analytic sample was evenly split by gender. The small proportion of non-binary respondents represented in the unweighted sample was 0% in the weighted sample due to the very small number of self-reported non-binary students in the university reported student statistics. Nearly two-thirds of the weighted sample identified as heterosexual. While three-

Table 1. Demographic characteristics of the unweighted and weighted survey sample.

	Unweighted N = 1,097		Weighted N = 1,097
Characteristic	N (%)	N	% (95% CI)
Gender			
Man	418 (38%)	536	49% (45%, 52%)
Non-binary	46 (4.2%)	-	-
Woman	633 (58%)	561	51% (48%, 55%)
Ethnicity			
Non-White	301 (27%)	458	42% (38%, 46%)
White	796 (73%)	639	58% (54%, 62%)
Sexual Orientation			
Heterosexual	639 (58%)	709	65% (61%, 68%)
Gay or Lesbian	98 (8.9%)	90	8% (6.5%, 10%)
Bisexual	277 (25%)	232	21% (18%, 24%)
Unknown	83 (7.6%)	66	6% (4.6%, 7.9%)
Student Status			
Undergraduate	593 (54%)	481	44% (40%, 47%)
Postgraduate	474 (43%)	527	48% (44%, 52%)
Other	30 (2.7%)	89	8% (5.6%, 12%)
Geographic background			
Domestic	730 (67%)	636	58% (54%, 62%)
EU	112 (10%)	11	1% (0.80%, 1.2%)
International	255 (23%)	450	41% (37%, 45%)

Abbreviation: CI: Confidence Interval.

quarters of the unweighted sample identified as White, in the weighted sample, this was just over half of the sample, indicating our response sample was overrepresented by White students. Postgraduate students represented close to half of the weighted sample, with the remaining sample being undergraduate visiting or continuing education students. In terms of where students were living prior to higher education, using the weighted sample, over half were domestic students and two-fifths were international students. [Table 1](#) describes sample characteristics across the unweighted and weighted sample. The remaining results are from analyses using the weighted sample.

Prevalence and nature of sexual assault and harassment

Reports of sexual assault were common across survey respondents. One in five student respondents (20.2%; 95% CI: 18%–23%) reported experiencing at least one type of sexual assault in the past year, with women more than twice as likely to report sexual assault than men (27.7%; 95% CI: 24%–32% vs. 12.4%; 95% CI: 9.1%–17%). Specific types of sexual assault included unwanted sexual contact (17.3%; 95% CI: 15%–20%), attempted rape (11.0%; 95% CI: 8.9%–13%), and rape (9.9%; 95% CI: 8.0%–12%). Gender disparities were consistent across all types of SV ([Figure 1](#)).

Sexual harassment was even more prevalent. Over two-thirds of respondents (69.4%; 95% CI: 66%–73%) reported at least one incident in the past year, and more than four in five women (81.0%; 95% CI: 77%–85%) reported this type of SV. The most frequent types of sexual harassment experienced by respondents were sexist hostility or sexist gender harassment (62.5%; 95% CI: 59%–66%) and sexual hostility or crude gender harassment (46.8%; 95% CI: 43%–50%), while a quarter experienced unwanted sexual attention (26.6%; 95% CI: 24%–30%) and nearly one in five reported sexual harassment via electronic communication (19.2%; 95% CI: 17%–22%) ([Figure 2](#)).

When describing their most significant experience of sexual assault, respondents most often identified perpetrators as men and, in most cases, as fellow students. Romantic or former romantic partners accounted for nearly one-third of perpetrators, while acquaintances and strangers were also identified as perpetrators. More than half of perpetrators were reported to have been using alcohol or drugs at the time of the assault and most assaults occurred at the university. Patterns were similar for sexual harassment. Again, perpetrators were predominantly men. Over half were other students, though some were identified as university staff, and others were not affiliated with the University ([Table 2](#)).

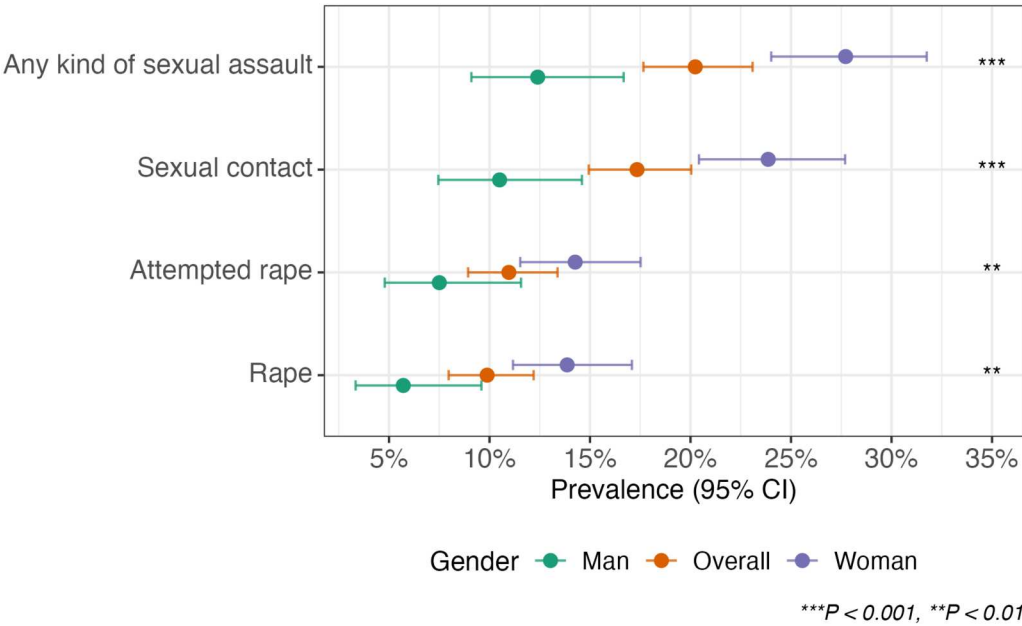


Figure 1. Prevalence of past year sexual assault among respondents, by type of sexual assault. Note: Significance tests were conducted to explore differences in scores between men and women.



Figure 2. Prevalence of past year sexual harassment among respondents, by type of sexual harassment. Note: Significance tests were conducted to explore differences in scores between men and women.

Table 2. Summary of perpetrator and incident characteristics with respect to respondents' self-reported most significant past year experience of sexual assault or harassment.

	Sexual assault N = 222		Sexual harassment N = 761	
	N	Proportion (95% CI)	N	Proportion (95% CI)
Perpetrator gender				
Man	178	81.0% (73%, 87%)	580	78.2% (74%, 82%)
Woman	40	18.2% (12%, 26%)	137	18.4% (15%, 22%)
Other	<5	~ 1%	25	3.4% (2.2%, 5.3%)
Perpetrator status				
Student	124	56.4% (49%, 64%)	430	57.9% (54%, 62%)
Staff	<5	~1%	70	9.5% (7.2%, 12%)
Both	<5	~1%	41	5.5% (3.8%, 7.9%)
Neither	74	33.7% (27%, 41%)	148	19.8% (17%, 23%)
Don't Know	15	7.0% (2.9%, 16%)	55	7.4% (5.0%, 11%)
Perpetrator using alcohol/drugs				
Yes	111	50.4% (43%, 58%)	-	-
No	43	19.5% (14%, 26%)	-	-
Don't Know	66	30.1% (23%, 38%)	-	-
Location of incident				
At university	135	61.1% (53%, 68%)	-	-
Elsewhere	86	38.9% (32%, 47%)	-	-
Perpetrator relationship				
Acquaintance	59	26.8% (21%, 34%)	-	-
Friend	49	22.4% (16%, 30%)	-	-
Romantic Partner	41	18.8% (14%, 25%)	-	-
Former Romantic Partner	25	11.2% (7.6%, 16%)	-	-
Stranger	46	20.8% (16%, 27%)	-	-

Note: CI: Confidence Interval. The questions about whether the perpetrator had been using drugs or alcohol, the location of the incident, and the perpetrator's relationship were not asked for sexual harassment and hence are blank. Values less than 5 are suppressed and percentages are not shown to protect respondent privacy.

Perceptions of safety and institutional response to sexual violence

Over a third of student respondents agreed that SV is a problem at their university. Significantly more women held this opinion when compared to men (Figure 3). Gender gaps were also evident in how respondents reported their perceptions of safety as students at their institution (Figure 4). While most respondents agreed that they felt safe from all forms of SV, women were significantly less likely to report feeling the same, with just over half of women reporting that they safe from SV. The types of SV that women felt most unsafe from sexual harassment and stalking (Figure 4).

When asked a series of questions on how they think their university would respond to a report of sexual misconduct, respondents, on average, did not perceive their university as being either supportive or not supportive (Figure 5). Women (2.30; 95% CI: 2.2–2.4) reported lower scores than men (2.70; 95% CI: 2.6–2.8) (Figure 5), indicating that women had less confidence that their institution would adequately respond to and support students reporting cases of sexual misconduct compared to men. The items with the lowest mean scores were actions that participants believed their university would be least likely to do in the event of receiving a report of sexual misconduct. These items were providing accommodations for the reporting student and addressing the factors that led to sexual misconduct.

Association between experiences of sexual violence and perceptions of safety and perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct

Experiences of sexual assault and sexual harassment were associated with lower scores on the scale for perceptions of institutional responses to a report of sexual misconduct. Women who experienced sexual assault had significantly lower scores than those who did not experienced sexual assault (mean difference = -0.43; 95% CI: -0.59, -0.26; $p < .001$), as did women who experienced sexual

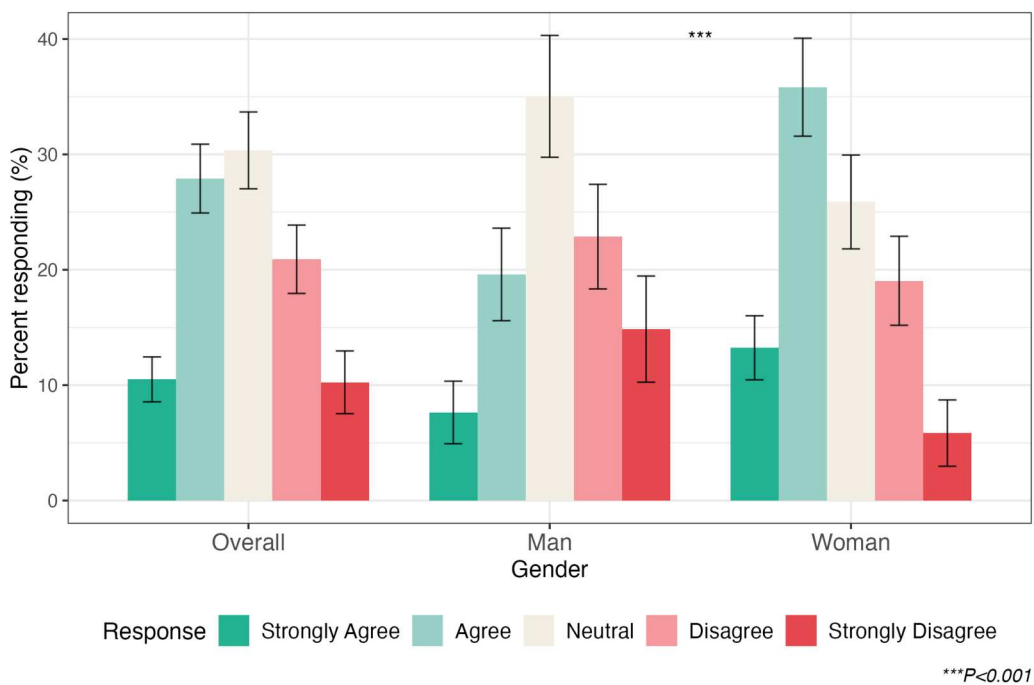


Figure 3. Percentage of respondents who indicated sexual violence is a problem at their institution. Note: Significance tests were conducted to explore differences in scores between men and women.

harassment, compared to those who did not experience sexual harassment (mean difference = -0.76 ; 95% CI: -0.93 to -0.58 ; $p < .001$). Among men, the mean score difference for those who had and had not experienced sexual assault was not statistically significant, likely because only a small number of respondents reported experiencing sexual assault (mean difference = -0.26 ; 95% CI: -0.62 – 0.09 ; $p = .145$). However, men who experienced sexual harassment reported significantly lower scores (mean difference = -0.34 ; 95% CI: -0.50 to -0.19 ; $p < .001$). Together, these results highlight the strong, negative association between sexual victimisation and perceptions of institutional responses to sexual misconduct (See [Figures 6 and 7](#)).

Discussion

The findings from the OUR SPACE 2024 survey contribute to the evidence base on understanding SV in UK higher education. We found that one in five respondents and 28% of women respondents reported experiencing at least one act of sexual assault within the past year and four in every five women experienced an act of sexual harassment. Over a third of the sample, and half of women respondents, indicated that SV was a problem at their university and around two in every five women respondents indicated that they did not feel safe from SV as a university student. Perpetrators of SV were identified by victims as being predominantly men and most often other students. Further, most assaults occurred at university locations, with alcohol or drugs involved in over half of the assaults. Participants in our survey who had experienced SV reported more negative perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct when compared to participants without experience of SV.

Our study offers new evidence on the prevalence and nature of SV within a UK university in the year preceding the implementation of national regulatory requirements on responding to SV by the OfS. Our results echo global research finding high levels of victimisation among students (Steele,

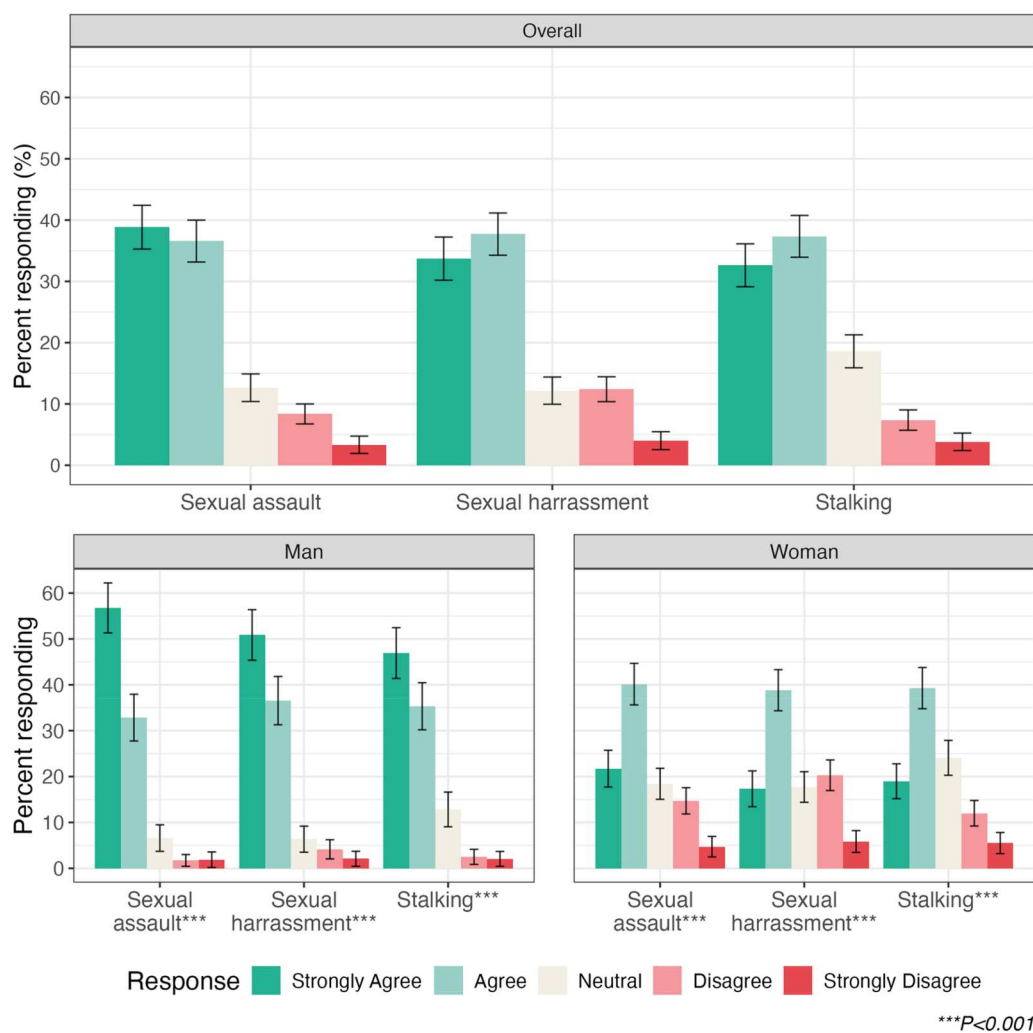


Figure 4. Percentage of respondents who reported feeling safe from specific forms of sexual violence at their institution. Note: Significance tests were conducted to explore differences in scores between men and women.

Martin, et al. 2024), offer UK specific insights and serve as a second iteration of a prevalence survey in the same institution in the UK (Steele, Degli Esposti, et al. 2024). To the best of our knowledge this is the first time an institution in the UK has repeated a prevalence survey. While both surveys were cross-sectional and administered three years apart from each other, findings remained relatively similar to the 2021 survey which found that the prevalence of past year sexual assault using weighted data was 17.7%, supporting the reliability of our survey tool and the findings (Steele, Degli Esposti, et al. 2024). There are important contextual factors to consider when comparing the surveys. The 2021 survey was administered during the COVID-19 pandemic and asked about past-year experiences which included periods of university closure, social distancing, and lockdowns, potentially reducing some of the risk factors for experiencing SV among this population and leading to lower average rates of SV. This could explain the higher rates of SV emerging from the pandemic (when compared to during the pandemic). However, we might also have expected reductions in SV from pre-pandemic rates of SV in the 2024 findings because of increased attention to the issue in the UK higher education context and increased investment preventing and

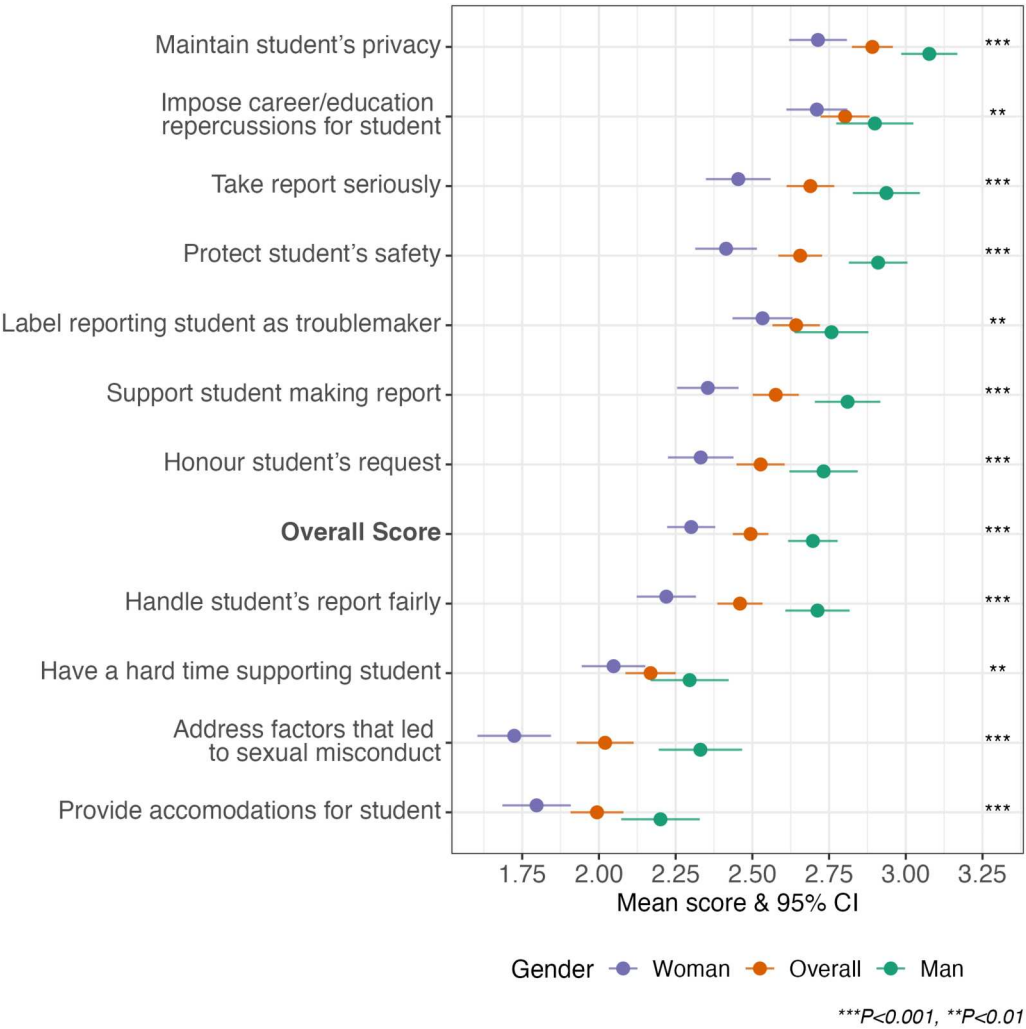


Figure 5. Average scores indicating participants’ perceptions of how their institution would handle a student report of sexual misconduct. Note: Item scores range from 0 (not very supportive) to 4 (very supportive). CI = confidence interval. Three items were reversed coded to allow for consistent interpretation of this figure: (1) Impose career/education repercussions; (2) Label reporting student as troublemaker and (3) Have a hard time supporting the student. For these items, a higher mean score means that respondents were less likely to think their institutions would respond in this way. Significance tests were conducted to explore differences in scores between men and women.

responding to student SV at our own institution. Routine data collection through the OfS and institutional surveys will allow researchers to understand trends over time and evaluate the impact of the OfS E6 regulatory conditions.

Steele, Degli Esposti, et al. (2024) discussed limitations to interpreting prevalence estimates due to the possibility of response bias; students who experienced SV might have been more likely to take the survey and modelled ranges of prevalence estimates depending on a variety of assumptions around bias. While this bias could persist in this survey, the results from the 2024 survey fall within prevalence estimates from other institutions in the UK and existing reviews (Anyadike-Danes et al. 2022; Roberts, Donovan, and Durey 2022; Steele, Martin, et al. 2024). Our results, however, show higher prevalence rates when compared to the OfS national prevalence survey which found across 51,920 final year undergraduate students that one in four students experienced

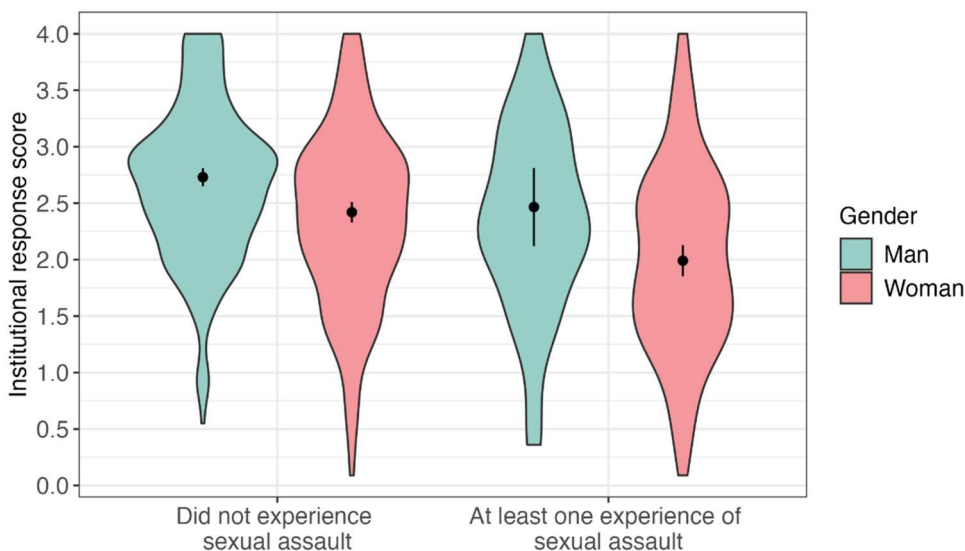


Figure 6. Weighted distribution of respondents’ perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct by gender and whether respondent experienced sexual assault in the past year. Note: Item scores range from 0 (not very supportive) to 4 (very supportive). Black dots indicate weighted mean values and bars indicate confidence intervals of the mean.

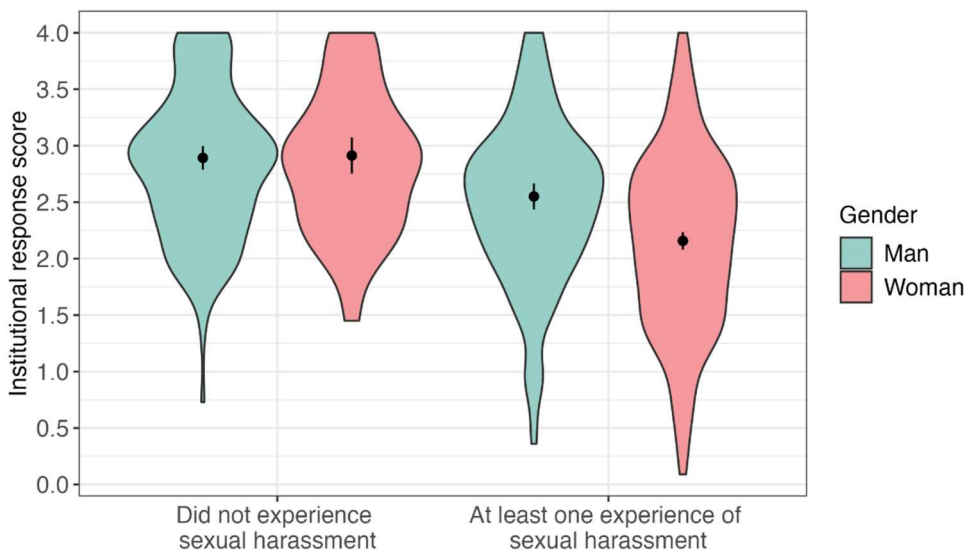


Figure 7. Weighted distribution of respondents’ perceptions of institutional response to sexual misconduct by gender and whether respondent experienced sexual harassment in the past year. Note: Item scores range from 0 (not very supportive) to 4 (very supportive). Black dots indicate weighted mean values and bars indicate confidence intervals of the mean.

sexual harassment and one in seven experienced sexual assault in the prior year. This could indicate that SV is more pervasive within the university where we conducted the survey, but the difference could also be explained due to methodological differences survey implementation; the OfS only surveyed final year undergraduate students and asked about past-year prevalence. This approach excludes the experiences of year undergraduate and graduate students who may face higher risks of SV.

Our findings on the nature of reported acts of SV are less prone to response bias and are conducted using a sample of 1096 past year reported instances of SV (260 instances of sexual assault

and 836 instances of sexual harassment). Our findings that perpetrators were mostly male students and known to the victim, reinforce feminist analyses of SV as an expression of gendered power relations (Armstrong, Gleckman-Krut, and Johnson 2018) and could potentially be explained by the pervasiveness of 'lad culture' in UK universities (Phipps 2017), where peer norms of misogyny and sexualised banter persist, normalise harassment and lower the threshold for more serious assault. The high prevalence of harassment reported, and the predominance of male perpetrators, also align with the continuum of SV (Kelly 1987) where everyday practices of misogyny normalise and sustain more severe forms of abuse and could be used to explain why women report feeling more unsafe from all forms of SV at their institution when compared to men.

Although higher education institutions globally and in the UK are increasingly making public commitments to address and respond to SV, students, and in particular women students, have more negative perceptions of institutional responses to sexual misconduct and feel less safe at their university. In our sample, respondents who reported experiencing sexual assault reported significantly lower confidence in institutional response to cases of sexual misconduct, which could potentially be characterised by feelings of 'institutional betrayal' (Smith and Freyd 2014, 575). When survivors feel further harmed when their university appears indifferent or untrustworthy, this could reinforce a culture of silence among survivors (Bull 2024; Shannon and Bull 2024). The OfS prevalence survey, began to evidence this, and found that most students experiencing an incident of sexual harassment or violence did not make a formal report or complaint about it to their university and of those students who did report, around a third described this experience as poor (2025). Further, respondents' general scepticism around trusting their university to appropriately handle a report of sexual misconduct suggests that the systems and culture might not only tolerate SV (as seen through prevalence rates) but may amplify harm through inadequate responses. However, the increased range in scores among participants who experienced SV could be explained by the fact that when institutions respond well to a report of sexual misconduct, it might in fact increase students' trust in the institutions (Bull 2024). It is important to note that our survey was administered prior to the implementation of the OfS E6 regulatory conditions on sexual misconduct nationally and at our institution, and therefore student experiences and perceptions could be expected to shift in the years since the survey was administered. Future surveys administered at our institution may have the opportunity to evaluate this hypothesis.

Overall, our results demonstrate that SV in higher education may be understood less as isolated events between individuals more as a range of behaviours and interactions operating within institutional structures and social norms that shape students' experiences, their sense of safety and their confidence and trust in their institution's willingness to respond. We suggest that higher education institutions are not just an environment where SV occurs but a factor that actively intersects with SV. The concentration of incidents, and the involvement of both students and staff as perpetrators, underscores the responsibility of institutions as organisational actors perpetuating the problem. Prior literature has highlighted the dangers of universities adopting a reputationally defensive posture (Hong 2023), downplaying or individualising SV rather than addressing the structural conditions that sustain it. We suggest institutional courage as an antidote to institutional betrayal manifested through transparency around the extent of the problem and the approach to handling reports, trauma-informed support, an understanding of risks involving alcohol and drugs, and leadership accountability might in fact be necessary for responding to this issue.

Limitations to the study design include the cross-sectional nature of the survey, which limits the ability to draw causal inferences between variables, and the response rate, relative to the sampling pool, impacting the representativeness of the sample. Students who experienced SV may have been more likely to respond to the survey. To help mitigate the issue of response bias, we weighted certain survey variables based on known total population characteristics and underwent a complete case analysis to deal with missing responses (Buskirk and Kolenikov 2015). It is also possible, however,

that survivors of SV were less likely to respond to the survey to avoid re-traumatisation. Further, the data relied on self-reported experiences, which subject to recall bias or underreporting due to stigma or fear of identification. While most of the measures in the study were validated, measures on sexual harassment in higher education have serious limitations, sexual discrimination which does not align with legal definitions of sexual harassment in the UK (Bull and Bradley 2026). Finally, the study was conducted at one specific UK university with distinctive structures and demographics. Findings may not be directly transferable to other higher education settings with different institutional cultures, governance systems, or student populations.

Conclusion

Higher education is a formative time of life for many in the UK; the opportunities provided through tertiary education can shape future employment opportunities, health, and economic outcomes. But it is also a time of increased risk and experiencing SV in higher education may limit fully benefit from the opportunities higher education offers. We argue that higher education is a critical point for intervention to reduce SV and that interventions must conceptualise SV in higher education an issue deeply rooted in gendered power relations and institutional structures. By drawing on theories of institutional betrayal and critical feminist approaches, we interpreted the quantitative results to reflect a gendered and institutional problem cutting across feelings of safety, experiences of SV, and confidence in institutional responses to reports of sexual misconduct. Our study contributes new empirical evidence to the UK literature on SV in higher education, affirming that prevalence rates are still high and that women students experience the highest rates. More evidence is needed strategies are effective for responding to this critical issue in higher education settings in the UK. There is cause for cautious optimism in the form of emerging policies in England from the OfS measurand prevent SV. Future research should build on this work by assessing the impact of new policies and employing techniques to reduce response bias. Such research should continue to apply feminist and intersectional analyses. For example, through exploring frequency of and analysing how race, class, disability, and sexuality intersect to shape not only victimisation risk but also access to support and justice. Ultimately, eliminating SV in higher education will require sustained collaboration between students, universities, and policymakers to foster campuses where safety, respect, and equity are ingrained in the institutional environments in which all students, regardless of gender or background, can thrive free from violence.

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ORCID

Bridget Steele  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-2028-558X>

Victoria Tan  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-4451-1588>

Michelle Degli Esposti  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-0068-5754>

David K. Humphreys  <http://orcid.org/0000-0002-7761-5746>

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